September 1985, the IB and Delhi Police unravelled a CIA espionage ring involving a South Delhi businessman with links to politicians along with nine American agents working undercover at the US embassy. The US government was quick to deny any allegations of spying and recruitment of agents. An official statement was issued to claim that no US government official sought or received classified information. While denying the allegations, the Americans conveniently ignored the details of the matter that emerged in Indian courts.

R&AW officials who had helplessly watched the CIA's activities in the country believe that the lure of easy money had made the Indians vulnerable. Though the majority of the compromised people were civilians working in different ministries, the American intelligence agency had consistently tried to plant a double agent in the top echelon of the Indian spy agency.

The opportunity to invade the R&AW came in the mid- 1990s when Indian decision makers approved increased liaisons with foreign intelligence organisations and exotic locations were chosen for rendezvous. A senior R&AW officer told me that such meetings hardly ever produced anything relevant to India's interests. He said: 'There is always a well-established mechanism within intelligence organisations across the world to share actionable inputs relevant to the countries concerned. But it is done within a Lakshmana Rekha (refers to a strict convention or rule, never to be broken). We went overboard and liaison meetings that yielded absolutely zero results were conducted without due diligence. Over a period of time, the exercise turned out to be counterproductive; it exposed our officers and some sensitive operations. The CIA was very keen to have R&AW harvests on Pakistan, China, Myanmar, Bangladesh, Afghanistan, Sri Lanka and Nepal. The Indian spy